



Obsessive-compulsive disorder

Obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD) is a common mental-health condition that affects men, women, and children. A person with OCD experiences repeated intrusive thoughts coupled with a need to perform specific actions over and over in order to relieve any associated anxiety.

OCD can strike at any age but typically develops during early adulthood. It can often be traced to a traumatic event or situation that occurred in childhood or adolescence and may stem from an out-of-proportion sense of fear, guilt, and responsibility linked to a particular incident.

The obsessive part of OCD is an unwanted and unpleasant fear, thought, image, or urge called an intrusion, which triggers feelings of anxiety, disgust, or unease. The compulsion aspect involves a repetitive behavior or mental routine that temporarily relieves

the intolerable anxiety brought on by the obsession. Both medication and cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) can be used to manage symptoms.

Genetic factors

About a quarter of OCD sufferers have a family member with the disorder, and studies involving twins suggest that a genetic link is likely. It is also believed that OCD disrupts communication in brain areas, including the orbitofrontal cortex, linked to feelings of reward, and the anterior cingulate cortex, linked to error detection.



Losing time to OCD

An overwhelming desire to carry out rituals is triggered by anxiety caused by an intrusive thought. This urgent need to count or check objects, wash hands, or repeat thought sequences can use up many hours every day.

Tourette's syndrome

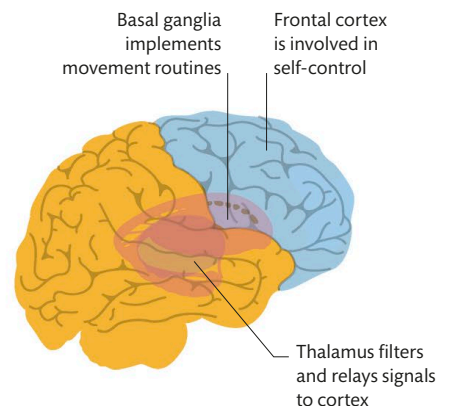
Tourette's syndrome is a complex neurological condition that causes a person to make involuntary sounds and movements called tics. It almost always develops during childhood, usually after the age of two.

Tourette's generally appears in early childhood, but before age 15, and is much more likely to affect males than females. Physical tics range from simple blinking, eye rolling, scowling, and shrugging to jumping, spinning, or bending.

The most publicized vocal tic is inappropriate swearing, although in reality this is rare and only affects around one in 10 of those with the disorder. The most usual verbal tics involve making grunting, coughing, or animal sounds.

Tics can cause pain due to muscle strain, and they often increase when a person is stressed, anxious, or tired. Symptoms can change and may improve over time, sometimes resolving completely.

Tourette's tics are often preceded by powerful sensations, like an itch or urge to sneeze. With practice, some sufferers learn to use these cues to control symptoms while in social situations such as school. People with Tourette's may also have OCD or learning difficulties.



Implicated brain areas

Tourette's tics are thought to result from an overproduction of the neurotransmitter dopamine, as well as dysfunction in brain areas linked to movement, such as the frontal cortex, basal ganglia, and thalamus.